



BEFORE

Once famous far and wide for its beauty, the Shenandoah Valley had been ravaged by two years of war.

A STRATEGIC PAWN

For the Union, the Valley had been a potential backdoor route to Richmond; to the South, it was the “**breadbasket of the Confederacy**” and the **natural invasion route to the North**.

CONFEDERATE CONTROL

In June, Union general David Hunter, who replaced Franz Sigel after the **Battle of New Market** (see [Valley defeats](#)), advanced back up the Shenandoah Valley and **put many buildings and homes to the torch**, outraging Virginians. Approaching the Confederate supply depot at Lynchburg, he was defeated on June 17–18 by General Jubal Early, commander of the new Army of the Valley. Hunter retreated into West Virginia, **leaving the Valley to Early**.

Jubal Early was nothing if not audacious. In June 1864, having won control of the Shenandoah Valley, he planned to take his Army of the Valley—Stonewall Jackson’s old Second Corps—on an invasion of the North.

Having scattered his enemies—some into the mountains of West Virginia—Early seized the opportunity to relieve pressure on Robert E. Lee, struggling with Ulysses S. Grant at Petersburg, Virginia. Early planned to threaten Washington, D.C., and perhaps draw off some of Grant’s soldiers. Crossing the Potomac River, Early brushed aside Union forces on July 9 at the Battle of Monocacy. Three days later, his men marched down Rockville Pike toward Washington’s defenses. Though the fortifications were manned by a force of militiamen twice the size of Early’s army, the city itself was on the verge of hysteria. The Confederates were so close that they could see the Capitol dome from their bivouac. But with thousands of Union reinforcements arriving from Petersburg, Early turned and soon recrossed the Potomac. He had sown panic and depleted Grant’s Petersburg lines, and had also destroyed railroads and telegraph stations.

Back in the Shenandoah Valley, Early continued defeating scattered Union incursions. On July 24, over the same fields and fences where Stonewall Jackson once fought, he vanquished Federal forces at the Second Battle of Kernstown. He then sent his